An Antarctic Island Looks Like a Skull, and Its Ice Is Telling a Story

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Seen from above, Vega Island in Antarctica looks like a grinning skull gazing toward nearby Devil Island. Behind that spooky sight is a serious story about changing **glaciers**.

Vega Island lies in the Weddell Sea, east of the Antarctic Peninsula. A **nunatak**, a rocky peak rising above the ice, resembles an empty eye socket. A lateral **moraine**, a ridge left along the side of a **glacier**, outlines the mouth, and the Bahia del Diablo, or Devil's Bay, **Glacier** forms the lower jaw.

NASA satellite images, captured by the Operational Land Imager aboard Landsat 9, show the island in March 2025 and again in October 2026. In March 2025, snow blanketed the terrain. By October 2026, extensive sections were free of snow, leaving darker **glacier** ice exposed.

Glaciologist Mauri Pelto of Nichols College explained that unusually warm conditions during the winter of 2026, especially in June, contributed to the exposed ice. Relatively little fresh snow accumulated, and some snow was lost through **sublimation**, when ice turns directly into water vapor, and through strong winds.

"The winter season was no treat for these **glaciers**," Pelto said.

The lack of snow could matter as Antarctica moves into warmer months. Fresh snow reflects much of the sunlight that reaches it, while darker ice absorbs more solar energy and is likely to warm more quickly, potentially speeding up melting. Even a thin cover of new snow from a spring storm would help in the short run, Pelto said. Continued melting could also change the island's appearance: "When entombed in snow and ice, the skull is preserved. But when exposed to melt, it weathers away, which will lead to a changing jawline and expanding eye socket."

Word Treasure

nunatak -- A rocky peak that sticks up above the ice around it.
moraine -- A ridge of rock and dirt left behind by a moving glacier.
glacier -- A huge, slow-moving river of ice.
sublimation -- When ice turns directly into water vapor without first melting into liquid water.
glaciologist -- A scientist who studies glaciers and ice.

Background you need

A glacier is a huge mass of ice that moves very slowly over land, shaping the ground as it goes.

Fresh snow is bright and reflects much of the sunlight that hits it, while darker ice absorbs more sunlight and warms up faster.

Satellites can photograph the same place at different times, so scientists can compare how much snow and ice is there.

When glaciers lose snow and melt faster, their shapes can change over time.

Break it down

LEAD: Vega Island looks like a grinning skull from above, and its ice tells a story about changing glaciers.

KEY EVENT: Satellite images show far less snow on the island in October 2026 than in March 2025.

+- WHO: Glaciologist Mauri Pelto of Nichols College, explaining the satellite views.

+- WHEN: Images from March 2025 and October 2026, after a warm winter in 2026.

EVIDENCE: A nunatak forms an eye socket, a moraine outlines the mouth, and a glacier forms the jaw.

OPEN QUESTION: Darker ice may warm and melt faster as daylight increases, though new snow could help in the short run.

Why it matters

Antarctica's glaciers hold vast amounts of ice, so changes in snow cover there can speed melting and affect sea levels far beyond the island.

Test what you remember

1. What does Vega Island look like from above?

- (A) A tall mountain
- (B) A grinning skull
- (C) A giant whale
- (D) A smiling face

2. What resembles an empty eye socket on Vega Island?

- (A) A lateral moraine
- (B) A snowstorm
- (C) A nunatak
- (D) Devil's Bay Glacier

3. What outlines the skull's mouth?

- (A) A glacier's jaw
- (B) A satellite
- (C) A lateral moraine
- (D) A nunatak

4. What did the October 2026 satellite image show compared with March 2025?

- (A) Extensive sections free of snow, leaving darker ice exposed
- (B) The island had disappeared
- (C) More snow everywhere
- (D) The island was completely frozen

5. What did Mauri Pelto say contributed to the exposed ice?

- (A) A new satellite
- (B) Unusually warm winter conditions, especially in June
- (C) Heavy rain in March
- (D) A volcanic eruption

6. Why does darker exposed ice matter?

- (A) It stops all melting
- (B) It reflects all sunlight
- (C) It makes the island colder
- (D) It absorbs more solar energy and may warm and melt faster

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: C 4: A 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Mauri Pelto, glaciologist at Nichols College: Explained that warm winter conditions, little fresh snow, sublimation, and winds left large areas of ice exposed, and warned darker ice may warm faster.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):